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HEAR THE ROOM

Echo... echo...

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Hear what the room is doing to *your guitar*.

A room changes the first reflection, decay and low-frequency balance before a plugin enters the chain. This experiment separates those effects from the performance.

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A guitar recording contains more than the guitar. The sound reaches a wall, floor and ceiling before some of it returns to the microphone. Those early reflections affect apparent size and tone. Later reflections form the audible decay most players call reverb.

The essay [The Room as Instrument](#) follows that idea through rooms such as Bearsville, Sound City, Electric Lady and Abbey Road. This GuitarHub version removes the studio tour and gives you a controlled test that works in a bedroom, rehearsal space or live room.

Do not compare three different performances

A player changes touch in response to what comes back from the room. That interaction is musically valuable, but it can confuse a technical comparison. Begin with one recorded performance so microphone position and simulated ambience are the variables you are testing.

A reamped electric guitar is ideal if you have a safe line-level reamping setup. If you do not, use a small speaker, acoustic guitar or phone playback at a moderate level. Protect your hearing and do not connect a line output directly to an amplifier input unless the equipment is designed for it.

Build three versions

Version A: close and dry

Place the microphone close enough that the direct sound clearly dominates. For an amplifier, start near the speaker and slightly off the center of the cone. For an acoustic guitar, start around the twelfth fret rather than directly at the sound hole. Record ten seconds and note the position.

Version B: farther into the room

Move the same microphone several feet back while keeping its height and direction consistent. Record the same source at the same playback level. The distant version will usually contain more room, but it may also lose direct detail or gain uneven bass because of the room's dimensions.

Version C: close with simulated room

Return to Version A and add a short room or convolution reverb. Do not change EQ or compression yet. Adjust the wet level until Version C feels roughly as spacious as Version B.

Level-match before you decide

Louder examples often feel fuller and more exciting. Reduce the playback gain of the loudest version until switching among A, B and C does not create an obvious jump. You do not need laboratory precision. You need a comparison that is not being won by level alone.

Then score each version on four questions:

1. Can you hear the beginning of each note without strain?
2. Does the decay support the phrase or overlap the next chord?
3. Does one bass note boom or disappear compared with the others?
4. Does the sound feel connected to a physical space, and does that help the part?

There is no automatic winner. A dry close sound may be right for a dense arrangement. A distant microphone may give a sparse clean part believable scale. A simulated room may offer the best control in an untreated space.

Find the useful position, not the perfect room

If Version B is harsh, move the microphone away from the nearest reflective wall or lower it below ear height. If the bass changes wildly, move the source or microphone rather than reaching for EQ immediately. Even a shift of a foot can move both away from a strong room mode.

If Version C sounds detached, shorten the pre-delay or decay and reduce the wet level. If it sounds too small, increase early reflections before extending a long reverb tail. Size and duration are related, but they are not the same control.

Turn the result into a repeatable note

Save the winning clip with five facts: the room, source position, microphone position, playback level and any added ambience. A phrase such as "large room sound" is not reproducible. "Amp two feet from the short wall, microphone four feet back at speaker height, short room at twelve percent wet" gives the next session a starting point.

Retest on another day before treating the setup as solved. Rooms change when furniture, doors, people and volume change. The note is a useful hypothesis, not a permanent law.

Guitar room-sound questions

Can a plugin reproduce a real room?

A good room or convolution reverb can reproduce important parts of a room's response and may be the best choice for the record. It does not recreate every interaction among speaker, floor, microphone and player. Compare the result instead of arguing from the tool category.

Is a distant microphone always more natural?

No. Distance adds room and changes frequency balance. In a poor position it can add comb filtering, noise or uneven bass. Natural does not automatically mean useful.

What if I only have a phone?

Put the phone in one fixed location and record the same phrase with the source close, then farther away. The phone limits fidelity but can still reveal changes in attack, decay and room balance.

The room is not decoration. It is one more variable you can test.

GuitarHub Field Guide No. 14. The latest version of this guide, with its tools and links, lives at guitarhub.org/resources/recording-guitar-room-sound.